

Cisco CCNA 200-301 - The Complete Guide To Getting Certified

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0.1 Host to host communications

0.1.1 A very basic introduction to networking

Let's say we have an office in NY. In that office there are end-hosts, such as PCs, server, printers, etc. All of the end hosts need to communicate with each other, for this we introduce a switch, this switch is going to be connected to each of the end-hosts using ethernet cables. A switch is a device with a lot of ports - which are basically slots to connect ethernet cables to - this allows the device to be connected to each other through the switch. The switch is what allows connectivity on my *local area network*. Let's say we add another end-host, a laptop, which is connected wirelessly to the same switch, the laptop will be connected via WIFI to a *wireless access point* and the wireless access point is connected to the switch via an ethernet cable. Now that all the end-hosts are able to communicate, we have built a *local area network*, which means a network that connects devices within the same local area, such as an office or a university campus. Now that we have built a local area network, we also want these end-hosts to be able to communicate with other devices out on the internet, not just in my local area network. For this we introduce another component, the *router*, which is a device capable of making advanced routing decisions to route traffic between different areas of your network. Next, now that we have connected the end-hosts to the local are network, and the local area network to the internet via a router. The internet is a very dangerous place, hackers can attack us and other things that we don't want can happen. For security reasons we install a *firewall*, which secures the different parts of our network from each other. In a larger company we would not just have end-hosts connected to switches connected to routers connected to firewalls connected to the internet. We would have similar local area networks in many other places, for example, we can say that we have a very similar local area network in Boston. The same devices and the same connections. Lets say we want the NY and Boston office to communicate directly without using the internet. We can use a *dedicated connection* between my two routers on both sites for communications to be direct from the NY router to the Boston router, this is called a *wide area network*. All this is expressed in the next, *network topology diagram*.